AZAD SAMAJ PARTY/ UP

A Shot in the Arm

By Prashant Srivastava

On June 28, Chandrashekhar Azad, the Bhim Army chief and national president of the Azad Samaj Party (ASP), was visiting Deoband in Uttar Pradesh's Saharanpur district when four assailants in a car opened fire on his sports utility vehicle. Providence was on his side. One of the bullets just grazed past his abdomen, and he was out of the hospital the very next day.

The attack on the 37-year-old Dalit lawyer/ activist-turned-politician comes at a time when his party is in talks on a possible anti-Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) alliance in UP ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha election. He has not only survived the assassination bid, but may have in fact gained from it politically.



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POSTER BOY Chandrashekhar Azad's supporters detained during a protest in Lucknow, June 29

Azad had co-founded the Bhim Army, a social organisation working for Dalit welfare, in 2014, and launched the ASP in 2020. A failed attempt to forge an alliance with the Akhilesh Yadav-led Samajwadi Party (SP) saw the ASP go solo in its maiden assembly contest in 2022. But Azad, who had challenged chief minister Yogi Adityanath from the Gorakhpur seat, finished fourth, even losing his deposit. This debacle prompted him to first focus on organisation-building across the state besides once again making efforts to join hands with "like-minded" parties.

Coming against this backdrop, the June 28 attack will not only help him gain sympathy, say political observers, but also give him better bargaining power in the Opposition camp. And Azad has lost no time in trying to strengthen his political capital. Even as the UP police, in coordination with their counterparts in Haryana, managed to apprehend the four alleged assailants within three days of the attack, the Bhim Army chief has trained his guns on the BJP government, both in UP and at the Centre.

"My 56-inch chest is real, not fake," he said after the attack, taking a swipe at Prime Minister Narendra Modi. "The attack on me is a failure of the [Yogi] government, as it is its responsibility to provide security to the people of the state." Not just that, Azad also hinted at the crime being the handiwork of "government-backed criminals...to eliminate Opposition leaders".

Days before the attack, Azad had told INDIA TODAY that he is in favour of a larger Opposition alliance to take on the BJP, "but first, we need to see who is in the Opposition and who is working for the BJP". It was a clear dig at Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) supremo Mayawati, whom Azad has now questioned for her "silence" on the attack. The fact that Azad wants to replace Mayawati as the face of Dalit politics in UP is not lost on anyone. Political observers say that even the SP-Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) combine is keen on bringing him on board to further marginalise Mayawati and tap into the votes of Scheduled Castes, who account for 20 per cent of UP's population. ASP insiders confirm they will fight the 2024 election in alliance with the SP-RLD though the "seat-sharing formula is yet to be decided".

"Azad's future depends on the choices he makes," says Lucknow-based political analyst Dr Shilp Shikha Singh. "Joining the Opposition alliance will add to his stature while also benefitting the grouping." But, for now, it is a choice made by his assailants that has inadvertently given a fillip to Azad's political ambitions. ■

By Romita Datta

As expected, an orgiastic bout of violence gripped rural West Bengal over the filing of nominations for the three-tier panchayat polls. The nomination process for around 74,000 seats began on June 9, the last date of filing papers was June 15—six days given over to arson, rampant use of bombs and bloodshed. Even after that date, the violence has continued unabated. At least 11 people have been killed and dozens injured. The BJP, Congress and the Left parties have accused the ruling Trinamool Congress of intimidating their candidates to stop them from filing nomination papers and from campaigning. The TMC has denied all charges, claiming that a record number of nominations were filed. It pointed out how several of its members/ workers were killed and injured. Bengal now awaits another cycle of bloodletting on the day of voting on July 8 (results are out on July 11). However, polling will take place under the watch of central armed paramilitary forces under orders of the Calcutta High Court.

In the meantime, being the main brand ambassador of her party, Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee has been on an overdrive to assure voters that their best interests lie in trusting her. Mamata has asked voters to consider her as the candidate in all seats. To take the wind out of the sails of a resurgent Left and the Congress, she personally apologised for any irregularities TMC office-holders might have committed. About arch-rival BJP, she had this to say: "Bengal is at peace and the BJP cannot bear that." She has also asked supporters to treat the polls as a war against the Opposition and appealed party members to be united. That's unsurprising, for infighting within the TMC is rampant and around 7,000 disaffected members are fighting the polls as independents.

With these local body polls being the last such pan-state